# *Have You Heard of Oscar Wilde?*

Stephen Fry

I grew up in the country, deep in the country. The nearest major library was a twelve-mile bicycle ride into the city of Norwich. I was lucky to live in a house filled with books and to have parents who loved to read, but by the time I approached teenage my appetite for reading, combined with my more or less chronic insomnia, meant that I needed more, far more books to consume daily. Every other Thursday, a mobile library (in the form of a large grey pantechnicon that would today look absurdly old-fashioned) would come along and park not five minutes' walk from our house. This was my lifeline to the outside world. A quaint battleship-grey modem that linked me to the huge past and present that seemed so impossibly far from the lanes of rural Norfolk.

Aged eleven, one Saturday afternoon I sat in front of our little black and white television set (despite the glowering disapproval of my father who thought – quite rightly of course – that television was a vulgar and despicable thing and that no healthy child should watch it, especially during the hours of sunlight) and watched breathless with enthralled disbelief as they screened a film directed by Anthony 'Puffin' Asquith. It was called The Importance of Being Earnest and it left me simply boggling with excitement. I had never heard language used in such a way, had never known that the rhythms of a sentence could be so beautiful, that meanings could turn with such wit on the hinge of a 'but' or an 'unless' – in short I had never known that writing could do more than tell a story, that it could excite in the way that music does. I remembered whole lines of dialogue and repeated them: phrases like 'I hope, Cecily, I shall not offend you if I state quite frankly and openly that you seem to me to be in every way the visible personification of absolute perfection' and 'some aunts are tall, some aunts are not tall. That is a matter that surely an aunt may be allowed to decide for herself'. I hugged these to me as I watched the credits roll by and memorised a name.

The following Thursday I ran to the corner of the lane and threw myself inside the mobile library the moment the door at the rear had opened and the steps been let down. 'Have you heard of Oscar Wilde?' I squealed to the cardiganed librarian within who clutched her beads in alarm at the urgency and intensity of my attack. 'Goodness me, young man ...' 'Do you have a play he wrote called The Importance of Being Earnest?' 'Well now ...' 'Please, I have to read it!' After what seemed an age we found a copy which was duly stamped. I ran home and up the stairs and into my bedroom.

I read The Importance of Being Earnest three or four times a day every day for two weeks. Then I returned it. I knew the whole play off by heart and can still distress companions with long quotations from it. 'What else do you have by Oscar Wilde?' I wanted to know. It was a different librarian and she found me a copy of the Complete Works.